

June 1, 2026

Javier Tapia — Principal
Portola Charter Middle School (LAUSD)
18720 Linnet St, Tarzana, CA 91356
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(818) 654-3300

Dear Principal Tapia,

I am applying for the math teaching position at Portola Charter Middle School for the 2026-2027 school year. I bring a BSc in Mathematics and Computer Science from Brown University, 20 years as a software engineer, and five years as founder and sensei at Dragon and Crane Dojo — a traditional karate studio I built from the ground up.

A throughline of my career has been novel curriculum development: working in Seoul Korea designing language lesson textbooks at a Hagwon tech startup, developing as president of a Toastmasters club new workshop formats for ESL speakers to overcome their hesitance to give their first speech, and most recently as a karate sensei developing an off-the-mat curriculum relating movement to such diverse fields as linguistics, geometry, pedagogy, and chess. For example, I relate the circular and linear trajectory of kicks to Euclid's treatment of lines and circles as fundamental objects of geometry, and that said kick's angle of 30 degrees incline means its height above belt height is $\frac{1}{2}$ the length of the leg. At the same time, my experience as both sensei and coder has taught me an appreciation of the simple fundamentals of clear communication and patient, structured repetition in helping a learner reach their goals.

I am excited for the opportunity to further discuss my unique blend of innovation and fundamentals to bring to the Portola Charter Middle School, even as what I learn in the classroom of what students struggle with and relate to can inform my parallel teaching at the dojo. Thank you for your time and consideration.

Sincerely,

David Chung
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